to the company when the Swadeshi fever was sweeping through the country. Many did want to support an indigenous enterprise especially in the context of the collapse of the British Arbuthnot and Company and the misery it caused to its investors. But with the government making its hostile intentions clear, by early 1908, a change in the support/investor base—dwindling as it was—is discernible. The small sums that reached the company were those of ardent nationalists desperately hoping that their little contribution would somehow save the day.



As of mid-April 1907, according to the district superintendent of police of Tirunelveli, 848 shareholders had taken 12,472 shares and paid-up about Rs 2.5 lakh.[111] Four months later, on 25 August, the company itself stated that Rs 2,83,061 had been paid up.[112] Though initial subscriptions came quickly, there were difficulties in collecting the full value of subscribed shares as investors defaulted on subsequent calls.[113] Subscription did not mean that the complete share price had been paid. Only the initial call of Rs 5, i.e. one-fifth of the share value had been called at the time of allocation. Efforts were made to collect the second instalment from the company's shareholders.[114] VOC stated in a public talk at Salem that about 2,500 shares were subscribed to but not many had actually paid up.[115]

By early November 1907, more than 20,000 shares had been issued to at least 1,700 shareholders. As noted above, two share certificates have survived: the first is share no. 11779 issued on 26 August 1907 to S. Saminatha Mudaliar of Sirkazhi. The other surviving share certificate, issued to one S. Nagalingam Pillai of Thadalankoil, Sirkazhi on 10 November 1907, is numbered 20662 (see p. 404). Therefore, in about two and a half months, nearly 9,000 shares had been sold. An impressive figure that redounds to the credit of VOC's relentless campaigning.

Though the company was making good progress and giving BI a run for its money it was not all smooth sailing. The difficulties were primarily financial. The capital raised, though substantial, was not adequate.